



Hybrids are smart watches with elegant, designer looks (Source: Misfit)



Watch with inflatable cuff helps monitor blood pressure (Source: Omron Healthcare)



Looking for a soulful wearable? Well, Lief could help you control stress (Courtesy: Lief)

you can stick on your body or stitch onto your dress. As technology uptake improves, concerns about security and privacy are sure to be ironed out. So let us take a look at some of the hottest devices in this space without dampening your enthusiasm.

Watches and bands continue to rock

There is something very convenient about watches and bands—you can just snap them on or remove when you want. This makes them one of

the easiest wearable technologies. That said, some expert trend-watchers claim that the popularity of watches and bands has plateaued with the emergence of less obtrusive forms of wearables like patches. Nevertheless, there were many exciting options on show at *Consumer Electronics Show (CES)* this year.

The usual fitness band and smart-watch players came up with newer versions with additional features. Garmin, for example, showcased Fore-runner 645 Music, a watch with music support. You can store and play up to 500 songs, neatly organised as playlists. Plus, this watch also includes Garmin Pay support, so you can use it to pay for stuff you buy.

Omron showcased HeartGuide, a blood pressure monitoring smart-watch that can be used for general fitness or healthcare purposes. The watch, which is pending FDA approval, uses an inflatable cuff to take blood pressure readings. You can take oscillometric readings at the press of a button or set the device to automatically take readings throughout the night. The data can then be pushed to a smartphone app and shared with your doctor. The watch is also capable of regular smartwatch tasks like notifications, sleep tracking and step counting.

Casio unveiled a rugged sports watch, GPR-B1000, with solar-powered GPS navigation. A five-hour charge enables standard GPS functioning for 33 hours. Thereafter the watch can instantly resume its GPS functioning if held in bright light. If left in sunlight for four hours, the watch gains enough solar charge to operate the GPS for an hour more. So, you can continue running even after sunset.

Casio's Triple Sensor technology collects compass bearing, atmospheric pressure, altitude and temperature data. Navigation features are similar to other on-watch navigation systems such as Garmin and Tom-Tom. The screen is small, but the route is visible enough for you to stay on track. You can zoom in and out if required. The dust-proof and dirt-proof watch can withstand harsh weather conditions, and is a good bet for trekkers!

But, these bulky watches are not

for the fashion-conscious folks. Small and elegant hybrid watches are what they like. Hybrid watches look like stylish designer watches with a dial, two arms, *et al*, but deliver the functionality of smartwatches. These are ideal for people with small wrists who are not comfortable with large sporty smartwatches.

There are several hybrid watches from brands like Armani Exchange, Emporio Armani, Michael Kors, Kate Spade, Diesel, DKNY, Tory Burch and Fossil. One of the recent interesting launches is Misfit Path, which is claimed to be Misfit's smallest hybrid so far. It has a stainless-steel case with matte finishing. A three-axis accelerometer tracks steps, calories burnt, distance travelled, sleep, etc together with the smartphone app that lets you set goals, and create alarms and reminders. It also connects to your smartphone and delivers calls, text messages, emails and notifications. With the press of a button, you can control music, capture photos and locate your phone if you misplace it. The device is water-resistant. Its replaceable battery lasts up to six months, so you need not bother about charging.

Patches growing popular

Of late, with the advent of flexible materials and electronics, patches are becoming very popular. These are handy and unobtrusive, and do their jobs better as they sit snugly, closer to the body. While it is fashionable to wear a sports watch or fitness band, not many people want to show off their health monitoring tech aids. After all, who will want to wear a watch that measures electrolytes in sweat, and explain it to their friends too?

An unobtrusive patch that disappears below your clothing is just right for such healthcare purposes. Patches are very convenient for monitoring health conditions, predicting trends and preventing harmful consequences.

According to statistics from Technavio, the global wearable patch market is expected to grow quickly through 2020, driven mainly by the US market. Research firm Tractica expects connected wearable patches to be one of the biggest drivers for body sensors. According to their report, wearable